

Great Canon with the Life of St Mary of Egypt

Wednesday Evening: 6pm

Livestream will be broadcast, starting at 6pm: <http://www.youtube.com/orthodoxnet/live>.

Our parish family is separated physically, but we are not separated spiritually if we pray together. Prayer binds us and helps not only us, but the entire world. We will live-stream the prayer service, for the benefit of anyone who wants to pray with us. Please do not just put on the service on and drink a cup of coffee or relax in some way that you would never do in church.

The service is very long, and therefore I have some suggestions for you.

Tune in at the beginning of the live-stream. You may even start 15 minutes in. By that time, we will be very close to the point will read the first half of the life of St. Mary of Egypt. It is critical to listen to this life, as it is read in the church. It is good to read it ourselves, and I've done this many times however when it is read in the church, God touches the heart. I know that it's hard to listen to all of the life pay attention at all times, but if we do what we are able to do, God makes us able to do what we are not able to do.

When we are listening to the life of St. Mary of Egypt, we are listening to the best example of repentance the church has for us. It is a fantastic story, only believable by those who begin to experience repentance in their life. Every word of it is true, and every word of it can be true for our lives.

After the first half of the life of St. Mary is read, Odes 1,2,3 of the Canon will be chanted. The Canon is much longer than other canons, but probably in 20 or 30 minutes, Ode 3 will be completed, and then we will read the second half of the life of St. Mary.

If you have the endurance, at least listen and pray till the entire life of St. Mary is read. I don't really remember, but I think that the reading of St. Mary's life will be completed well before 7 o'clock. **That would mean that you would dedicate less than an hour of your time to pray and to listen to the best example and model of repentance. That is a very good use of your time.**

We will continue serving after the entire life of St. Mary is read, finishing the Canon and doing all of the other appointed hymns for the matins service. I understand that this is very long especially when you're standing at home and when the feed may sometimes cut in and out and other such things like that. **I think everyone can make a commitment to pray at least for the first hour of the service. That is what I am asking you to do as your pastor.**

Father Nicholas and I are serving alone, that is when I serve at the church, he is not present and vice versa. This is my week to serve all the way through this coming Sunday. I don't sing very well, and have not organized the services for many years, so I beg your indulgence because there may be some "boo-boos" and mistakes. None of that matters if we are trying to pray and struggling to be attentive.

Tomorrow evening, we will serve a **Paraklesis service to the Theotokos for the healing of Matthew**, who is currently in the hospital. I will text an invitation to everyone I have on my texting list, and also email the invitation to our mailing list, and put it on Facebook and Twitter. This will mean that I will probably start the meeting and then do all of the informing about the meeting, but the screen will be blank for a while. Please be patient!

Matthew Norris is the youngest child of Michael and Catalina Norris. You should lift up prayers for Matthew every day, and not stop. We are probably going to have a zoom meeting which everyone can log into when we do the Paraklesis because the Paraklesis Canon is sung beautifully by Matushka Genevieve and her children, and they will be at home. I will be at the church. I can also sing it, but I don't sing it as well, so we are going to try to use technology to have the priest serving in the temple, and the choir singing from home.

On Friday evening, we will live stream the **Akathist service for the Theotokos**. We are also going to do this via zoom meeting, because, as is usual, Matushka Genevieve and family can sing the Canon much better than me. Since I will be serving in the temple, I will be singing the Akathist.

I have the ambition to serve the **Divine liturgy on Saturday morning**. I will let you know that the ambition will be satisfied. Father Nicholas and I want to take every advantage to serve every liturgy we can, because the liturgy is not just for those who are present, but it is for the

entire world. Our major contribution as Orthodox Christians during this COVID-19 pandemic must be that we pray. We must do other things as well, such as be aware of his restrictions by the civil authorities and directives of our Archbishop Peter, and we also must be aware of the needs of others, financially, emotionally, spiritually. We must be very active during this pandemic even if we are mostly at home, and every activity must start with prayer and continue with prayer and conclude with prayer.

We will certainly serve Vigil on Saturday evening(5pm), and Divine Liturgy in the morning (10 AM). We intend to live stream these services. We will also make available the printed Typica for Sunday. It is a much shorter service than the liturgy, and I recommend that your family would chant the Typica service at 9 o'clock, and then pray during the live stream starting at 10. If you can do one or the other, I think praying the Typica is paramount.

If you participate in any live stream or zoom meeting during our prayer, light your vigil lamps, and stand by your icon corner, and treat the service as is if you were standing in the temple. Note: that does not mean that you should go to the kitchen to get a drink of water every 10 minutes! :) Cross yourself when you would normally cross yourself, and bow when you would normally bow. If the priest does a prostration, you should do a prostration. It may help your attention to sing the responses, when you know them.

We are in extraordinary times, and have an opportunity to gain great grace if we pray during this pandemic. Don't squander this opportunity!

Priest Seraphim, Rector and very, very junior choir director and singer.

Text resources:

This letter:

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-09_2020-04-01+livestream-services-schedule.pdf

http://www.orthodox.net/articles/pastoral-letter-corona-virus-09_2020-04-01+livestream-services-schedule.doc

Life of St Mary of Egypt

<http://www.orthodox.net/saints/mary-of-egypt.docx>

<http://www.orthodox.net/saints/mary-of-egypt.html>

<http://www.orthodox.net/saints/mary-of-egypt.pdf>

<http://www.orthodox.net/saints/mary-of-egypt.rtf>

The Great Canon Thursday the fifth Week of Great Lent:

<http://www.orthodox.net/greatlent/great-canon-fifth-week.html>

<http://www.orthodox.net/greatlent/great-canon-fifth-week.rtf>

<http://www.orthodox.net/greatlent/great-canon-fifth-week.pdf>